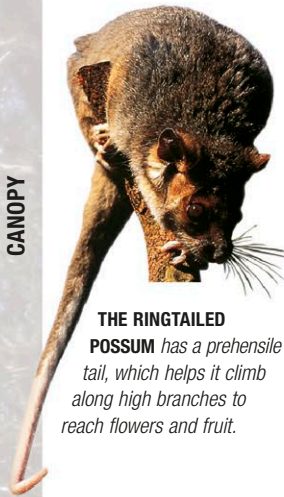
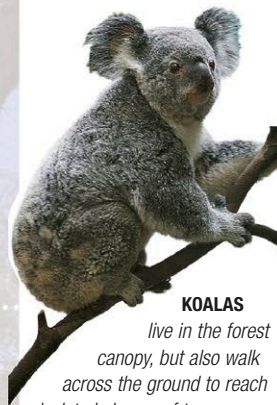


CANOPY



THE RINGTAILED POSSUM has a prehensile tail, which helps it climb along high branches to reach flowers and fruit.



KOALAS live in the forest canopy, but also walk across the ground to reach isolated clumps of trees.

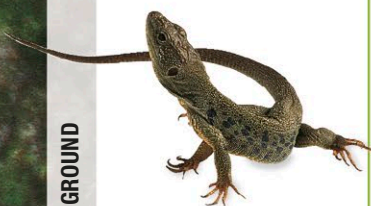


THE AUSTRALIAN GREEN TREEFROG has exceptionally thick skin to minimize moisture loss and enable it to deal with the dry conditions in evergreen forest.



BUSH CRICKETS and other insects, such as beetles, provide food for reptiles and mammals that live on the ground.

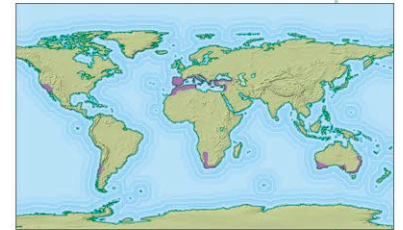
GROUND



SUN-SEEKING lizards and snakes often bask in the warm sunlight that bathes the forest floor.

Evergreen forest

In warm parts of the temperate world, many broad-leaved trees are evergreen. Unlike trees of deciduous forest, which grow in spring and summer, evergreens grow in winter and spring, when temperatures are low but not cold, and when water is readily available. Described by botanists as sclerophyllous (meaning hard-leaved) forest, this habitat is found in several widely scattered regions of the world, including parts of California and western South America, the Mediterranean region in Europe, and large areas of eastern and southwestern Australia. In some of these places, the forest is low-growing, but in Australia, where eucalyptus is the dominant species, it includes the tallest broad-leaved trees in the world.



TEMPERATE EVERGREEN FOREST is found in regions with a Mediterranean-type climate: mild, damp winters, and warm, dry summers.

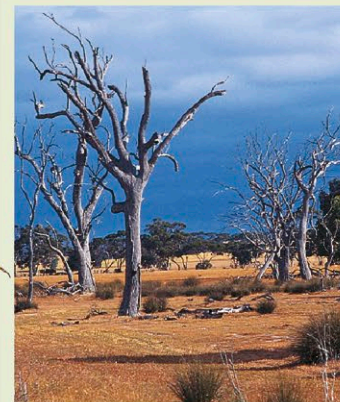
Temperate evergreen trees usually have open crowns, which means that the vertical layers are often less pronounced than they are in forests in cooler regions, and plenty of light is able to reach the forest floor. As a result, these forests are rich in ground-based wildlife, and warmth-loving animals—such as lizards and butterflies, which are usually associated with higher levels—can often be seen sunbathing on the floor. The open structure also makes it easy for birds, such as kookaburras and other forest kingfishers and rollers to swoop down on animals moving around on the ground.

The air in evergreen forest often smells pleasantly aromatic because most of the leaves are filled with pungent oils. These oils help to stop the leaves from drying out, and they also protect them from animals. They are a highly effective deterrent, as relatively few animals—apart from specialists such as the koala—include these leaves in their diet.

SALINIZATION

In Australia, the arrival of Europeans has brought huge changes to the continent's forests, with their unique plants and wildlife. Millions of acres have been cut for lumber, claiming some of the world's tallest broad-leaved trees, and displacing woodland animals. Even more land has been cleared for grazing and for crops, sometimes with unintended consequences. One of them is salinization—a process that mobilizes subterranean salts when native vegetation is removed.

Salinization often kills surviving trees, turning them into gaunt skeletons that take many years to decay.



SALTY SOIL
These Australian eucalyptuses have been killed by salinization—rising salt levels in the ground. Salinization is caused by forest clearance, which changes the water balance of the ground. Salinized land is useless for agriculture.